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# Critical self-reflection: What is it and how do you do it?

Learning the skills of critical thinking and critical reflection is essential for the development of critical citizens in any society. These are not straightforward skills and do not come naturally to the majority of people. The school system is not designed to develop skills of critical, independent thinking in its students, and our socialization in learning to become (unquestioning) members of society rarely fosters a critical attitude. For most adults, it is not until they undertake some form of tertiary education or travel to other cultures that they become aware of perspectives other than those offered by their family, schooling, religion, workforce experiences and the media. In this paper I define reflection, examine the distinctive features of critical reflection, locating it theoretically and outlining the differences between critical thinking and critical reflection; distinguish between values, beliefs and assumptions; and outline some strategies and techniques for improving skills in critical reflection. I also discuss how critical reflection is central to reflective practice, especially for students engaging in partnerships in community contexts.

## What is reflection?

The root of the word 'reflection' is the Latin *reflectere*. *Flectere* means 'to bend', so *re-flectere* increases the inflection—'to bend back', or to bend again or double-take. The meaning of the word has come to be interpreted as an introspective 'bending in', i.e. a reviewing of our own inner processes of thinking and feeling (Bleakley, 1999).

John Dewey is considered a key originator of thinking about reflection (Dewey, 1933). He thought of it as a 'special form of problem solving, thinking to resolve an issue which involved active chaining, a careful ordering of ideas linking each with its predecessors' (Hatton & Smith, 1995, p. 33).

Dewey argued that reflective individuals have certain characteristics: open-mindedness, a willingness to accept intellectual responsibility for one's own views, wholeheartedness (i.e. a willingness to face fears and uncertainties) and enthusiasm. Literature on reflection, developed from Dewey's ideas, focuses primarily either on *adult learning* (Boud, et al., 1985; Brookfield, 1995; Mezirow, 1990), or is concerned with reflection in relation to *practices and actions*, especially professional practice in fields such as teaching (Hatton & Smith, 1995; Yost, et al., 2000), nursing (Burns & Bulman, 2000) and social work (Fook, 1996), drawing on the pioneering work of Donald Schön (1983, 1987). Schön's work emphasises the concept of 'reflection-in-action', where the reflective practitioner evaluates intuitive understandings intrinsic to experience as a guide to action. This 'on-the-spot' processing is somewhat different from retrospective contemplation, which characterizes most reflection on learning.

## Literature on service learning

There is also a developing body of literature dealing with reflection on the service-learning experience, which may be useful for you to refer to as you move into reflecting on your learning (for example, see Ash & Clayton, 2004; Bringle & Hatcher, 1999; Correia & Bleicher, 2008; Eyler, 2002; Felten, et al., 2006; Iles, 2007; Power, 2010).

# Types and levels of reflection

Writers in the education tradition have identified different types and levels of reflection. For instance, Van Manen (1977), following Habermas (1972), distinguished three types, involving a progression through three distinct stages of reflection: technical, practical and critical, each of which is associated with particular assumptions about knowledge.

**Technical reflection** is concerned with efficiency and effectiveness of means to achieve certain ends, i.e. the effective application of skills and knowledge. Knowledge is used to control the environment, and such knowledge is viewed as objective and value-free.

**Practical reflection** allows for examination of goals and the assumptions on which they are based and recognizes that meanings are negotiated through language and communication. Knowledge is viewed as socially constructed and individuals seek to develop a sense of shared values and norms within their particular contexts.

**Critical reflection** adds moral and ethical criteria such as equity and justice, locating analysis of personal action within wider historical, political and social contexts. Knowledge is viewed as being constructed by particular interests and maintained through relationships of power.





Similarly, Goodman (1984) distinguishes three *levels* of reflection available to the reflective practitioner.

The **first level** (the technical or evaluative) is limited to technocratic issues of efficiency, effectiveness and accountability, e.g. the practitioner might ask '*have I achieved my goals in the best way possible?*'

In the **second level** (the practical or sense-making), the practitioner would assess the implications and consequences of your actions and beliefs as well as the underlying rationale for your practice, e.g. the practitioner might ask 'what are the implications of my actions?' or '*what sense can I make of my experience?*'

The **third level** (the critical) is where issues of justice and emancipation enter deliberations over the value of professional goals and practice and the practitioner makes links between the setting of everyday practice and broader social structure and forces e.g. the practitioner might ask '*how do my actions reflect my values and beliefs and how do they reflect relationships of power?*'

### Critical reflection is not 'negative criticism'

'Critical' in this context is aligned with the notion of 'critique' in the sense of undertaking a particular form of analysis that attempts to bring to light taken-for-granted assumptions and demonstrate how these reinforce power relationships, such as those between different classes in society or between mainstream and marginalized groups. This is distinct from the more everyday sense of the word critical as meaning 'negative' or 'destructive'.

Critical thinking and critical reflection are terms often used interchangeably, which can be confusing for students if not clearly defined. I make the distinction as follows (Fisher 2003):

**Critical thinking** and critical analysis involve processes of abstract reasoning, detecting the assumptions underlying *another's position or text* and identifying how such assumptions serve particular interests (Bowell & Kemp, 2001; Brookfield, 1987; Brown, 1998; Chaffee, 2003; Paul, 1993).

**Critical reflection**, on the other hand, is a process attached to looking at one's *own positioning*, requiring a level of self-awareness, and is generally more difficult because of the unquestioning acceptance of many unconsciously-held beliefs and assumptions, particularly those that are supported by our social institutions and structures. Given the *personal* nature of critical reflection, I will make this explicit by referring to this process as **critical self-reflection**. It is important to note that a capacity for critical self-reflection enhances capacities for critical thinking and analysis (Mezirow, 1990).

Barnett (1997) goes further and argues that there are *three* skills that are required for integration into what he calls a 'critical being': critical thinking, critical self-reflection and **critical action**: Each of these is associated with a different domain: critical thinking is associated with *knowledge*, critical self-reflection is associated with *self* and critical action is associated with *world*.

> *"The full potential of critical being will only be achieved, therefore, through the integration of its expression in the three domains of knowledge, self and world, and in being lived out at the highest levels of critique in each domain. Through such integration of the critical spirit, critical but creative persons will result, capable of living effectively in the world "*
> (Barnett, 1997, p. 8).

**Barnett's critical being**

| Skill | Domain |
|---|---|
| Critical thinking | Knowledge |
| Critical reflection | Self |
| Critical action | World |

## What distinguishes critical reflection?

The conceptual basis for critical reflection originated in critical theory (Bronner & Kellner, 1989; Geuss, 1981; Habermas, 1972), a theory of society that has as its goal a just and democratic society that will come about through the emancipation of its citizenry. Such a process entails 'reasoned confrontation of the dominant, science-influenced rationality which privileges means over ends, facts over values, and which perpetuates arid intellectualism at the expense of people's feelings' (Reynolds, 1998, p. 187). Such a 'reasoned confrontation' permits the lifting of 'the veils of illusion' that keep people oppressed through demonstrating the extent to which their own beliefs, practices and values operate against their own interests—this is the primary purpose of critical reflection according to critical theorists. The questioning of assumptions, the 'taken-for-granteds' (Reynolds, 1998), particularly those that reflect relationships of power within social and political contexts, is the key difference between critical reflection and other forms of reflection.

# What distinguishes critical reflection?

Educators have identified the 'emancipatory' intention behind acts of critical self-reflection as crucial to distinguishing it from other forms. Emancipation comes from forces which limit our options and exercise control over our lives, but have been taken for granted as being beyond human control. It requires gaining an in-depth understanding of our own historical situation. It means becoming critically aware of how and why the assumptions we make have limited the way we see ourselves and our relationships, changing these assumptions in a liberating fashion, towards a more discriminating and integrating experience and acting on the new understandings. Mezirow (1990) calls this 'perspective transformation'.

Transformative learning thus requires critical self-reflection, which essentially involves questioning assumptions underlying our beliefs, reassessing these assumptions, exploring alternative perspectives and acting on the new meaning perspectives thus generated. As individuals, we 'breathe in' an ideology or meaning perspective of the particular social group that provides the immediate context of our socialization (e.g. being a white middle class Australian woman). Each person also has individual characteristics which don't fit with the dominant social perspective and what can happen is a 'constant negotiating and conflictual process between individual and social group' (Kennedy, 1990, p. 100). This negotiation process is not conscious. The social structure appears to be a given, but as people experience other perspectives or sense contradictions they will wonder about and question the received givens. This can be the first step towards a critically reflective attitude. This often happens the first time we realize that what our parents told us may not necessarily be true!

> *"Critical reflection involves a critique of the presuppositions on which our beliefs have been built … [Such critique involves] challenging our established and habitual patterns of expectation, the meaning perspectives with which we have made sense out of our encounters with the world, others, and ourselves"* (Mezirow, 1990, pp. 1,12).

The main features that distinguish a **capacity for critical self-reflection**, as distinct from other types of reflection, include being able (and willing) to:

- uncover, examine and question one's own assumptions, values and beliefs, particularly those that are cultural and historic in one's own perspective or account of events (Dewey's 'wholeheartedness' and 'responsibility');
- consider other perspectives or alternative ways of viewing the world, i.e. being able to identify what perspectives are missing from one's own account of events (Dewey's 'open-mindedness');
- identify how one's own views have a particular bias that privileges one view over another (Dewey's 'responsibility');
- perceive contradictions and inconsistencies in one's own story or account of events; and
- imagine other possibilities, i.e. a capacity to envision alternative ways of thinking, feeling or acting (Fisher, 2003).



# Values, beliefs and assumptions

Before we look at some strategies and activities that assist the process of becoming critically self-reflective, it may be useful to be clear about the **distinction between values, beliefs and assumptions**, as the meaning of these terms is often not clearly understood. These are not easy concepts to define and they operate in interdependent ways. The boundaries between these definitions can be fuzzy, so there are often overlaps and ambiguities. I have developed these definitions to help my own understanding—you may find you have different understandings and meanings that suit you better. To illustrate, I will offer general examples related to reflecting on civic learning in partnerships with community organizations.

As a student learning within a community context, you will be drawing, whether consciously or unconsciously, on values about what is important to you about having this type of experience, about the type of organisation you are in partnership with and the values espoused by that organisation. Such values may have been forged as you grew up and reflect your own formative experiences. They may have been influenced by your first experiences with visiting other cultures or working or studying with people from different backgrounds. You may find that the values expressed throughout your experience with the organisation or your reading for this course may also influence you or give you pause to reflect, especially if they challenge your own. I would suggest that consciously identifying these values is an important step towards becoming a more aware and effective citizen, a *critical being* engaged in the world.

I encourage you to start thinking about your values in preparation for your community experience. One of the most rewarding experiences we can have as learners is to be challenged by people and organizations that express values different from our own.

**Values** reflect what we think is good, right, desirable, worthwhile and reflect how we believe the world should be. They provide the foundation upon which we make personal and professional judgments and choices—in effect they are principles that we live by and help define who we are. While many of our values have a strong moral and ethical foundation, much of what we value is not concerned with our sense of morality or ethics. Some writers find it useful to distinguish between non-moral or instrumental values, such as the desire for job security, friendship, health, wisdom, peace, and moral values which have an ethical base, such as integrity, honesty, respect, caring, justice, civic virtue, and openness (Ursery, 2002). Some values refer to how we think we should act (e.g. be courageous, altruistic, spontaneous) while other values refer to what we wish to accomplish or obtain in life (e.g. a lot of money, fame, a family, world peace). We may find that our fundamental moral values change little in our lives. On the other hand, some of our values may change as a result of significant experiences that change our way of seeing the world. The key question to ask in determining what values you may hold is: *what is important to me*? Of course, our behaviours may not always be consistent with our professed values.

Examples of values that may influence the way you approach your service-learning experience include:

- *respect* for authority
- *respect* for the autonomy of the individual
- *social justice*
- an *ethic of care* for people worse off than ourselves
- *civic virtue* (i.e. being a good citizen)

# Values, beliefs and assumptions

**Beliefs** are positions we hold that represent how we think the world operates, what we think is 'true'. They reflect the way we think the world is (rather than the way it should be). Beliefs are often based in our socialization and generally only come up for question when there is that conflict between what the dominant or prevailing societal view might be and our own experience. Beliefs are often strongly connected to values, both moral and non-moral. They are more likely to change when they are demonstrated to be false through convincing information and/or experience, particularly if we have those qualities of open-mindedness and wholeheartedness. Beliefs are also underpinned by assumptions. The key question to ask in determining what beliefs you may hold is: *what do I think is true?*

Examples of beliefs about community organizations, for instance, might be:

- all community organizations are poor
- community organizations are a drain on the taxpayer
- people who work in community organizations are selfless
- what we learn at university is no use to community organizations
- community organizations can benefit from what we learn at university

Note that the language suggests 'this is how things are', rather than 'this is how I would like things to be', although each of the above statements reflects a value position, e.g. social justice, authority, control etc.

**Assumptions** are presuppositions that we take for granted that are the basis for how we act in the world—they can be about people we know, about cultures, about the way human beings behave, about the nature of reality, about knowledge. They are the unstated, taken-for-granted ideas that we carry around with us unconsciously. They are usually based on our values and beliefs about the world. Thus, while we *hold* a value or belief, we *make* assumptions that our unexamined values and beliefs are true and valid. Thus:

unexamined values + unexamined beliefs → assumptions

We act on the basis of assumptions all the time—without assumptions we would not be able to function effectively in the world. However, processes of critical self-reflection can help reveal what assumptions we might be making, what we might be taking for granted that is not based on verifiable information. People are generally more easily able to name their values than the assumptions underlying their beliefs. It is also quite difficult to identify the extent to which assumptions are cultural and historic, as they appear to have the appearance of 'this is just how the world is'. Questioning our assumptions can often mean disorientation, discomfort, a 'lost innocence'. The key question to ask in determining what assumptions you may hold is: *what do I take for granted*?

Some assumptions (unexamined values and beliefs) that might underlie the examples given above include:

- poverty means not having enough money
- individuals should be responsible for their own behaviour
- altruism is better than selfishness
- real learning comes from experience
- educated people know more than people who haven't been to university

# Strategies to assist critical self-reflection

Many people can find this process of questioning assumptions confronting and uncomfortable, as well as difficult to do. It can feel like one's very foundations are being undermined, which in a way they are. This discomfort is generally a sign that a 'meaning perspective' is being challenged and is ready for change. It is a sign that real learning is happening. I would strongly suggest that it is worthwhile persevering to experience the satisfaction of greater self-awareness through such perspective transformation. This final section outlines different strategies that you might find useful to assist your process of critical self-reflection.

## Critical friends

Learning how to develop skills of critical self-reflection is not an easy process—it is built on questioning and enquiry. However, it is a process that is made even more difficult if it is done without support—in many ways reflection, while an inner process, is assisted through interaction with others, particularly those with different perspectives from our own. One effective strategy is the formation of 'critical friend' relationships between people who are willing and able to give and receive constructive feedback, especially questioning unaware assumptions. Effective relationships are most likely to be formed between people with different belief and value systems as well as different backgrounds as it is generally easier to identify assumptions held by another that differ from our own. Skills of giving feedback sensitively and asking open questions are also important in assisting critical reflection.



## Critically reflective questions

Learning the skills of asking questions that elicit critically reflective responses is an important part of the development of critical friend partnerships. The following are examples of the types of questions you could ask as a critical friend in relation to civic learning experiences:

1) What influenced you to choose your community project?
2) What aspects of your background experience and knowledge might have been relevant in this choice?
3) What values underpin your approach to your community project?
4) What beliefs do you think you might be taking into your community setting?
5) What underlying assumptions do you think you might be making, i.e. what could you be taking for granted about the community context?
6) What biases have become apparent to you through your experience in the project?
7) What other perspectives might you be ignoring in the way you approach your project?
8) What contradictions and paradoxes do you notice in the way you approach your project?
9) Think of another student you know who has different values—how does their approach differ from yours?

# Strategies to assist critical self-reflection

## Steps in reflective practice

The following series of steps and associated questions form part of a useful staged process for developing the skills of reflecting critically on your project (adapted from Gibbs, 1988). It works best when you can identify a 'critical incident' where you might have felt uncomfortable or confused or when conflict arose:

1. **Description**: *what happened?*
2. **Personal experience:** *what was I thinking and feeling?*
3. **Evaluation:** *what was good and bad about the experience?*
4. **Analysis:** *what sense can I make from this experience?*
5. **Confrontation**: *what values, beliefs and assumptions did I carry into this experience? Where did they come from? How do they differ from the values, beliefs and assumptions of others involved in the experience? How do they connect to wider social and political forces? What are the ethical implications of my actions?*
6. **Reconstruction:** *what could I have done differently? What will I do differently next time?*

In steps 1-3 the practitioner is engaging in Level 1 *technical (evaluative) reflection*. By step 4 they have moved to Level 2 *practical (sense-making or analytical) reflection*; and by the time they have reached steps 5 and 6 they are engaged in Level 3, a genuine *critical self-reflection* on their practice. People new to reflective practice usually keep their reflections fairly descriptive – the goal is to deepen reflection by moving through the three levels. It takes time and practice, particularly with the help of a critical friend and regular journal writing (see below). Ultimately it is well worth the effort and essential to becoming a more effective critical citizen.

## Reflective journals

Learning through reflection is ultimately an individual process. People can give advice and hints and tips, but it is really only possible to learn by having a go. A particular method or strategy that works for one person may be a hindrance to another—the reflective journal is one strategy that many people find helpful. It may be an adjunct to a critical friend relationship or replace it. Here is one practical exemplar of how a reflective nursing practitioner uses a reflective diary (Johns in Palmer, et al., 1994, p. 123):

1. *Use an A4 notebook and split each page*
2. *Write up diary of events on left hand side. Use right hand side for further reflections/analysis notes (such as steps outlined above).*
3. *Write up experiences same day if possible.*
4. *Use actual dialogue wherever possible to capture the situation.*
5. *Make a habit of writing at least one experience per day.*
6. *Balance problematic experiences with satisfying experiences.*
7. *Challenge yourself at least once a day about something that you normally do without thought/take for granted; ask yourself 'why did I do that?' ( make the 'normal' problematic).*
8. *Always endeavor to be open and honest with yourself—find the authentic 'you' to do the writing.*



### Preparatory reflective activity

This reflective exercise is a useful way to start the process of critical self-reflection:

*Take some time to sit quietly with yourself and either write or talk into a tape recorder—if appropriate, involve your critical friend in the process. Think about your childhood and the person you are now. Think about yourself in your own personal, social and historical context. Answer the following questions, recording your impressions freely, without editing your thoughts and feelings:*

- *What were you like as a child, physically, mentally, emotionally and spiritually?*
- *Where did you live and what was it like?*
- *Who were the important people in your life?*
- *Why were these people important to you?*
- *What other influences were important in your childhood, such as other people, places and events?*
- *What were some of the 'rules for living' you learned from these people, places and events?*

*Make some connections now to your professional work or primary activity:*

- *What influenced you to do the work you are doing now?*
- *Who were some of the important people in your life that helped shape the worker you have become?*
- *What is important to you in the way you do your work?*
- *What, if any, childhood 'rules for living' have been transferred into your professional*

## Concluding remarks

In this paper, I have attempted to clarify and demystify the complex concept of critical self-reflection through exploring its different dimensions and offering strategies that may assist you in developing this important skill. While reflection is a particular form of thinking, it is important for you to distinguish critical reflection from critical thinking/analysis and to be clear what is being asked of you in your assessment.




Critically reflective capacities take time and support to develop, and while this paper offers some guidance, there is no substitute for practice and engagement with others in the reflective process.

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